

American Journal of Agricultural Economics

Refereeing Criteria for judging the merits of journal submissions

1. **CONTRIBUTION.** Does the paper make a significant contribution to its field of research and where relevant have implications for policy? Does the paper say something worth saying? Is it timely?
2. **SCHOLARSHIP.** Is the scholarship sound? Does the paper meet academic standards? Do the facts check out?
3. **APPEAL.** Is the topic important? Would it appeal to a large enough section of our readership?
4. **ORIGINALITY.** Does the author bring a fresh perspective to the topic? Does it duplicate or recapitulate other works? Is it novel, correct and insightful?
5. **ANALYSIS.** Are all the facts examined and the information analyzed correctly? Is more than one side of the issue presented?
6. **ILLUSTRATIONS AND LENGTH.** Do the illustrations, tables, graphs and appendices add to the paper? Is the paper concise? Could the author make the same point in a Note or short paper? If so, suggest what might be condensed or omitted.

A referee report should consider whether these criteria are met and explain why or why not, as well as point out the strengths and weaknesses of the paper. Detailed comments on why the paper is acceptable or unacceptable are necessary to the author as well as the editors. If a weak paper can be rewritten to make it of value, we would expect the referee to give specific guidelines for doing so. The report should be constructive, and should not include any personal remarks or personal details including your name.

When making a recommendation regarding an article, a referee should select a category for classifying the article and explain the reasons in the report to the authors as well as in his/her confidential letter to the editor.

- (a)** **Reject:** This category should be chosen if the paper has some fatal flaws or those that would require such significant revisions that it would make it into a new paper.
- (b)** **Weak Revise and Resubmit:** This category should be chosen if the paper has significant shortcomings but you believe that it may be possible for the authors to revise it to make it acceptable
- (c)** **Strong Revise and Resubmit:** This indicates that the paper stands a good chance of a successful revision and the referee strongly supports giving the authors the opportunity to revise the paper
- (d)** **Accept without revision:** This indicates that the paper is in very good shape and can be accepted for publication as is.

If choosing (b) or (c), the referee should clearly identify what revision is required, and indicate to the editor whether or not he/she would be happy to review the revised article. A typical 2-3 page report should take about 3 or 4 hours. Keep in mind that the AJAE rejects about 85% of papers received and very rarely is a paper accepted at the time of first submission.

THANK YOU VERY MUCH!